

The French Bean, *seed to sale*

A single Kenyan crop cycle runs roughly **75–90 days**. Here is the whole arc, and everything in between.

The cycle, by date

Worked example, planting Wed 15 Jul 2026. Dates shift with your sow date.

✓	PHASE	DATE(S)	WHAT TO DO	NOTES
☐	Plant Day 0	Wed 15 Jul 2026	Sow at 30×15 cm , DAP in the furrow (off the seed), irrigate in.	
☐	Germination & emergence Day 3–8	Sat 18 Jul 2026 – Thu 23 Jul 2026	Emergence in 5–8 days. Keep soil damp. Scout bean fly from day one.	
☐	Gap-fill Day 9	Fri 24 Jul 2026	Replant blanks to keep a uniform plant stand.	
☐	1st top-dress (CAN) Day 14–18	Wed 29 Jul 2026 – Sun 2 Aug 2026	At 2–3 leaf stage: CAN ~60 kg/acre (split). Weed now.	
☐	Vegetative growth Day 8–30	Thu 23 Jul 2026 – Fri 14 Aug 2026	Steady water ~50 mm/week. Scout aphids & whitefly.	
☐	Flowering Day 30–40	Fri 14 Aug 2026 – Mon 24 Aug 2026	2nd top-dress (CAN) as flowers open. Even moisture + thrips control are critical.	
☐	Pod fill Day 40–48	Mon 24 Aug 2026 – Tue 1 Sep 2026	Finish sprays, respect pre-harvest intervals. Watch rust / anthracnose.	
☐	First harvest Day 45–50	Sat 29 Aug 2026 – Thu 3 Sep 2026	First pick around day 45–50. Pick young, straight, string-free pods.	
☐	Harvest window Day 45–70	Sat 29 Aug 2026 – Wed 23 Sep 2026	Rolling ~3 weeks. Fine: pick 2×/week · extra-fine: 3×/week. Early-morning picks.	
☐	Close-out & rotation Day 75–90	Mon 28 Sep 2026 – Tue 13 Oct 2026	Uproot, sanitise residues, rotate to a non-legume next.	

CROP CYCLE	FIRST PICK	ALTITUDE	TEMPERATURE	SOIL pH	WATER NEED
75–90 days	Day 45–50	1000–2100 m asl	18–27 °C	6.5–7.5	~50 mm/week

THE CYCLE, PHASE BY PHASE

Day 0

1. Planting

Time it so the **first harvest lands in the buyer's window**. Under irrigation you can plant year-round; rain-fed growers plant at the onset of the rains.

- Spacing **30 × 15 cm** (rows × plants); 1–2 seeds per hole, 3–4 cm deep.
- Basal fertiliser: **DAP ~80 kg/acre**, mixed into the furrow, keep fertiliser off the seed to avoid scorch.
- Work in well-rotted manure/compost for organic matter and water retention.

NEEDS STEADY MOISTURE

DAP BASAL

Day 3–8

2. Germination & emergence

Seedlings break ground in **5–8 days** with warm soil and moisture. Keep the bed consistently damp, no waterlogging.

- Gap-fill blanks early to keep plant population uniform.
- Scout for **bean fly** from emergence, it tunnels stems/roots and kills young plants; treat at first sign.

Watch, bean fly: the most damaging early pest. Wilting, yellowing, swollen/cracked stem bases. A drench or approved systemic at emergence protects the stand.

Day 8–30

3. Vegetative growth

The plant builds its frame. Feed it, keep it weed-free, and hold the water steady at roughly **50 mm per week**.

- **1st top-dress** at the 2–3 leaf stage: CAN ~60 kg/acre (split with the 2nd application).
- Weed early, beans compete poorly; a clean field now pays at harvest.
- Climbing types get staking/support; most export bush types don't.
- Scout aphids & whitefly (virus vectors) and foliar disease.

CAN TOP-DRESS #1

50 MM/WEEK

Day 30–40

4. Flowering, the make-or-break stretch

Flowers set the pods. Two things decide the crop here: **even moisture** and **thrips control**. Heat stress above ~30 °C causes flower drop and poor pod set.

- **2nd top-dress** (CAN) at the onset of flowering.
- Never let the crop dry out during flowering/pod set, irregular water = deformed pods = rejections.

Watch, thrips: they hide in flowers and scar developing pods. Scarred pods are downgraded or rejected outright by exporters. This is the pest that most often costs growers their export grade.

Compliance, spray discipline starts now: every product must be buyer-approved with its pre-harvest interval respected. Log every spray. A KEPHIS phytosanitary pass does **not** guarantee residue (MRL) compliance, residue testing is separate, and importing markets enforce strict limits.

Day 40–48

5. Pod formation & fill

Pods elongate toward picking size. Hold irrigation steady and finish any spraying so that **pre-harvest intervals expire before the first pick**.

- Keep scouting rust, angular leaf spot, anthracnose & halo blight, cool wet spells drive them.
- Stop residual-risk sprays; switch to harvest-safe options only.

Day 45/50 →
~70

6. Harvesting

The payoff, and it's not one event, it's a **3-week rolling harvest**. Pick young, tender, straight, string-free pods to the buyer's grade.

- **Fine beans: pick ~2× per week. Extra-fine: ~3× per week**, extra-fine must be caught younger and thinner.
- Pick in the cool of early morning; handle gently; keep out of the sun in the field.
- Harvest by hand into crates, never overfill; bruised pods are rejected.
- Regular, frequent picking keeps the plant flowering and pods within spec.

MARKET WINDOW = PREMIUM

GRADE TO SPEC

Same day, every pick

7. Post-harvest & cold chain

Quality now only degrades, the job is to **slow it down and move fast**. Beans are perishable; the cold chain from field to aircraft is what protects the value you grew.

- Field → collection centre → **pre-cooling** quickly; hold cool (~4–7 °C).
- Packhouse: sort, grade, trim, weigh, pack to buyer spec.
- **Phytosanitary certificate from KEPHIS for every consignment**; residue/MRL clearance for the destination market.
- Refrigerated transport to the airport → airfreight to market, typically within 24–48 h of picking.

PRE-COOL FAST

PHYTO CERT / CONSIGNMENT

COLD CHAIN

Day ~75–90

8. Close-out & rotation

When picking tails off and pods lose quality, **close the field cleanly**, the next crop's health starts here.

- Uproot and remove/compost residues to break pest & disease cycles.
- Rotate, **don't follow beans with beans**; go to a non-legume (e.g. brassica, cereal) next.
- Reconcile records: yields, spray log, rejections, feed them into the next contract.

ROTATE AWAY FROM LEGUMES

SANITATION

SOURCES

Agronomy & growing calendar

- > [Cropnuts: French Beans Farming Guide](#)
- > [Greenlife Kenya: French Beans \(2026 update\)](#)
- > [Standard Media / FarmKenya: All you need to know about farming French beans](#)
- > [Simlaw Seeds: Bean Production Guide \(PDF\)](#) (spacing, seed rate, DAP/CAN rates)
- > [Infonet-Biovision: Beans \(Phaseolus vulgaris\) agronomy & pests](#)

Regions, altitude, climate & earnings

- > [Tuko: French beans farming in Kenya: guide and earnings per acre](#)
- > [Business Radar: French Beans Farming in Kenya: Everything You Need to Know](#)

Export, market & compliance

- > [KEPHIS: EU DG SANTE audit on pesticide residues in food exports](#)
- > [Infonet-Biovision: Basic Export Requirements \(Fruit, Vegetable\) in Kenya](#)
- > [Standard Media / FarmKenya: What to do to export fresh French beans](#)